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This decision was actually quite difficult.

Especially at a moment like this.

In economics, there's a term called "sunk cost."

It refers to the time, money, energy, and other costs previously invested in something, but which are irrelevant to current and future decisions.

Clearly, the sunk cost of this decision was too high.

When Liang Shi had made that decision before, she had done so with the determination of burning her boats¹.

The pain was real, the sorrow was real, even the separation was real.

She had forced herself not to contact Xu Qingzhu, not to learn any news about her, not to see her even once.

As long as they got through this period, it would be fine.

They just needed to sign that divorce agreement.

Then they could exploit the bug in this world's operating rules.

At that point, it wouldn't matter how Xu Qingzhu punished her.

As long as Xu Qingzhu stopped having those nightmares, as long as she didn't become unlike herself.

But now, after seeing her just once, Liang Shi's defenses had crumbled.

Since it was causing Xu Qingzhu pain and sorrow either way, they might as well try to face it together.

If it really was as Xu Qingzhu said, perhaps they needed to love each other as if every day were the last day of their lives.

Only then would there probably be no regrets.

If there truly were regrets, it should be regretting not having met in another, better place.

Rather than like this—regretting not having loved.

Regretting having loved yet still parting.

But embracing Xu Qingzhu now, making promises, meant that all the steps Liang Shi had taken before were wasted.

They had only suffered for nothing.

But there's another saying in economics: "Sunk costs are not costs."

When Liang Shi held Xu Qingzhu, Xu Qingzhu's entire body was trembling—trembling continuously even while being held.

Xu Qingzhu buried herself in Liang Shi's shoulder and sobbed uncontrollably, tears soaking through her clothes.

Liang Shi's tears fell too.

By the end, both had cried themselves voiceless.

When their eyes met again, Liang Shi reached out and gently wiped away Xu Qingzhu's tears, saying with heartache: "Your eyes are so red. Stop crying."

Xu Qingzhu choked out: "I don't want to either, but I can't control it."

It wasn't like this before—it had just started these past few days.

Once she started crying, it was hard to stop.

Unless she cried herself to sleep.

There were even several times when she cried until her heart hurt so much she needed to pound her chest with her fist. Crying until she couldn't speak was a minor thing—once she nearly couldn't catch her breath, and she specifically went to see a doctor.

The doctor's response was that her pregnancy symptoms were quite pronounced. Her hormones were being secreted too vigorously, combined with emotional stagnation, leading to low mood and sensitivity, increased crying, and being unable to stop once she started.

It would get somewhat better later, but the first three or four months would be tough.

The doctor repeatedly reminded her not to have extreme emotional swings, to do some yoga suitable for pregnant women, listen to soft music, and regulate her mood.

But today she couldn't hold back, and once she started crying, she couldn't stop.

Liang Shi could only stroke her back to soothe her. "I'm sorry, it's all my fault."

Xu Qingzhu sniffled, feeling slightly better.

"I shouldn't have made decisions on my own, thinking I was being good to you." Liang Shi said, "I've always been timid, I..."

She paused, but the words that followed still didn't come out.

If she hadn't seen Xu Qingzhu today, she wouldn't have believed it either.

Liang Shi knew Xu Qingzhu liked her—one could even say loved her.

But Liang Shi didn't think anyone would love her this much, so much that they would willingly die alongside her tomorrow.

Liang Shi didn't think she was such a great person.

Her face was just average. Xu Qingzhu had seen so many beautiful people; her face wasn't anything special.

As for personality, someone in Xu Qingzhu's position could have any personality type she wanted.

Liang Shi didn't think she was special or unique. She had even thought about what she would do if Xu Qingzhu fell for someone else.

In a way, she was actually more rational than Xu Qingzhu.

In this relationship, she wasn't as steadfast as Xu Qingzhu.

Without Xu Qingzhu, she could still have friendship, have a career, do things she loved, see scenery she wanted to see.

Probably because from the very beginning, she had never claimed Xu Qingzhu as her own.

In her subconscious, Xu Qingzhu would meet someone who shared her aspirations.

She was merely a passerby in Xu Qingzhu's life.

In Xu Qingzhu's long life, she could only accompany her for one leg of the journey.

That one leg would be enough for her to reminisce about for half her life.

Perhaps if she was lucky enough, she could find someone else to love mutually.

This unforgettable first love would remain in her memories.

Or perhaps, like her previous life, she would never have lasting luck.

And she would live the rest of her days on memories alone.

In any case, Xu Qingzhu was not her first choice.

Rather than saying that, it would be more accurate to say that love had never been her first choice.

Footnotes:

¹ **Burning her boats (破釜沉舟):** A Chinese idiom literally meaning "break the cauldrons and sink the boats." It originates from a historical battle where a general ordered his troops to destroy their cooking pots and boats after crossing a river, leaving no option for retreat. It means to commit fully to something with no way back, similar to "burning bridges" but with the connotation of desperate determination.

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Liang Shi paused for a long while before continuing from her previous sentence: "I never thought anyone would ever... to me..."

But she got stuck halfway through.

She couldn't continue.

Compared to Xu Qingzhu's pure and passionate love, her bit of inferiority could only get stuck in her throat.

Like a thorn.

Liang Shi was neither pure nor passionate.

She was like a cup of tepid tap water, forever containing impurities.

Facing Xu Qingzhu, she couldn't say anything.

Words of defense, explanation, promises to make.

All gone.

What could she possibly say in the face of such love?

Anything she said would seem insignificant.

"Do you think that no one in this world would love you like this?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi closed her eyes. A tear fell as she slowly nodded.

Yes.

Who would love her like this?

The people who loved her had long since passed away.

Everyone being good to her was simply because she still had some small use value, or they only needed to give her a little something in return for her past kindness.

But in this relationship, Liang Shi felt she hadn't been up to par.

This was Liang Shi's first time in love.

Not romantic, not attentive, unable to understand her lover's heart.

Occasionally even a bit dense.

Xu Qingzhu had probably been angered to the point of coughing blood by her at certain moments.

Only to dissolve it alone with love.

She was clearly older than Xu Qingzhu, yet Xu Qingzhu always had to take care of her feelings.

"Why wouldn't there be?" Xu Qingzhu continued asking. "Don't you deserve it?"

Liang Shi was stunned.

After a long while, Liang Shi closed her eyes and said: "Because... I love myself too much."

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The reason Liang Shi could detach herself from this relationship at any time was because she loved herself too much.

She was always in a defensive state.

Because she worried that Xu Qingzhu might meet her destined person and leave at any time, she had to prepare herself to leave at any moment.

Liang Shi's rationality told her she had to do this.

Because almost no one had ever made decisions for her since childhood, she always had to make her own decisions.

And take responsibility for those decisions.

Her grandparents were so old and could barely read—how could they be responsible for her life?

Being able to give her the love within their understanding was already good enough.

So her life seemed stable on the surface, but she had always listed out Plans A, B, C, and D.

There was always a Plan B.

The only time she had never considered the consequences, the only time she had thrown caution to the wind, was when she absolutely had to return here.

Because she wanted to see Xu Qingzhu.

At that time, she felt she really did love Xu Qingzhu very much.

But when the rules of this world began operating again, her love became calculating once more.

So compared to Xu Qingzhu, her love was truly insignificant—even too embarrassing to speak of.

But unexpectedly, after hearing her say this, Xu Qingzhu simply raised her hand to wipe away her own tears and said to her very seriously: "Then love yourself well. I'll love you."

After saying this, Xu Qingzhu added: "On the condition that you're not allowed to leave anymore."

How could Liang Shi possibly withstand this? One sentence from Xu Qingzhu made her burst into tears.

Afterward, Xu Qingzhu turned around and comforted her instead.

The two stayed in the office for who knows how long, until Xu Qingzhu's stomach growled. Looking at her watch, it was almost one o'clock.

About three hours had passed.

Liang Shi glanced at her belly, her nose feeling slightly sour. But her emotions had basically stabilized. Hearing Xu Qingzhu's stomach growl, she looked over curiously, reaching out her hand then pulling it back, repeating this several times.

Xu Qingzhu took her hand and placed it on her belly. Her gaze as she looked down at her stomach was very gentle: "The doctor said there won't be any movement for now. We'll have to wait a while."

Liang Shi's hand gently caressed her belly. "So our baby is in here?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Yes."

"It feels so magical," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Xu Qingzhu probably didn't understand this feeling of hers.

Because in Liang Shi's previous understanding, two girls couldn't have children together.

But now, through the fusion of pheromones, they could conceive a child.

Was this perhaps the progress of technology?

And this little one was slowly growing in Xu Qingzhu's belly. In a few months, they would meet.

Liang Shi would once again have a blood bond.

A bond beyond just romantic love.

When Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu walked out of the office holding hands, agent Chang Hui was no longer waiting at the door. She had sent Liang Shi a message saying she had something to do and left early.

She probably didn't want to be a third wheel¹.

Besides, having been in this industry for so long, she was very perceptive.

This floor had a direct elevator to the parking garage.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu went straight to the garage to get the car. After fastening their seatbelts, Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu: "Do you want to eat out or at home?"

"Home," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi had no objections and drove home.

Footnotes:

¹ **Third wheel (電燈泡):** Literally "light bulb" in Chinese. This is slang for an unwanted third person who tags along with a couple, similar to the English expression "third wheel." The metaphor comes from the idea that a light bulb illuminates things that the couple might prefer to keep in the dark.

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She had clearly just seen Yujiang Bridge not long ago, and had come to this neighborhood too, but at that time the weather had felt gray and hazy.

Even the Yujiang River seemed to be covered in fog.

But during the day, everything was clear. The clouds had parted and the fog had dispersed.

As Liang Shi passed by Yujiang, she casually remarked: "The weather is really nice today."

Xu Qingzhu glanced over: "Yes."

But there was no sun today. The clouds were piled layer upon layer, gray and white intermingled.

There was a traffic jam on Yujiang Bridge, barely able to move an inch.

The water of the Yujiang wasn't as clear as before either.

After Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu got home, Liang Shi changed her shoes with practiced ease. Then, when Xu Qingzhu was about to bend down to change her shoes, Liang Shi immediately half-squatted and pressed down on her foot, took off her shoes, picked up slippers from the shoe rack, and carefully put them on for her.

Xu Qingzhu stood there, stunned.

Liang Shi looked up at her from this posture. "Did I change your shoes like this before?"

Xu Qingzhu slowly nodded.

Back then, Liang Shi had even kissed the top of her foot.

But Liang Shi had been drunk that time. The current Liang Shi was sober.

Perhaps the shoes didn't fit properly—the new shoes she bought were slightly too small, causing Xu Qingzhu's heels to be rubbed red. The skin near her pinky toe and big toe looked like it was about to peel.

Liang Shi stared, then suddenly reached out and pressed next to her big toe. Xu Qingzhu gasped in pain and instinctively tried to pull back, but Liang Shi held her foot and placed it on her own leg.

"What are you doing?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi sighed: "The shoes don't fit. New shoes need to be broken in before you can wear them."

"But you still have to wear them to break them in." Xu Qingzhu pulled her foot from Liang Shi's hands. "These are pretty, and I like them, so I can wear them. Whether they fit or not doesn't matter—as long as I can put them on, it's fine."

Liang Shi was helpless: "Alright then."

She got up to go to the bathroom to get hot water for a foot soak, but when she reached the doorway, she suddenly realized: "Are you using a metaphor?"

"It's a simile," Xu Qingzhu said without any bashfulness.

Liang Shi: "....."

Her ears felt a bit hot from what was said.

Xu Qingzhu was arranged to sit on the sofa by Liang Shi, while Liang Shi went to prepare medicinal foot soak packets and hot water, bringing them to the living room for Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi's sleeves were rolled up, revealing a small section of her forearm.

Her hair accidentally fell down and nearly dropped into the water. Xu Qingzhu caught it just in time, saving her hair from disaster.

Liang Shi bent down and squatted there, placing Xu Qingzhu's feet in the basin. "Soaking will make it feel better."

Xu Qingzhu patted the spot beside her. "Then come join me."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Aren't you hungry? I'll go make you something to eat," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu stared at her.

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu asked slowly in a melancholic tone: "Liang Shi, are you caring about me or the baby?"

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi was stunned: "You, of course."

Xu Qingzhu's mood improved slightly, but she still complained: "But you only started being this nice to me after I said I was pregnant. I think you love the baby more."

Liang Shi: "....."

"How can you think that?" Liang Shi asked in surprise.

Xu Qingzhu was even more surprised: "Why wouldn't I? Think about what you've done."

Liang Shi: "....."

"When you first entered the office, you were still asking if I'd considered the divorce," Xu Qingzhu said. "Then after I said I was pregnant, you said we wouldn't divorce. If it's not because of the child, what else could it be?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"It's because you cried." Liang Shi was squatting, needing to tilt her head up slightly to see Xu Qingzhu's face—just the right angle to look up at her.

Those light brown pupils looked at Xu Qingzhu earnestly: "You were crying like that. My heart shattered."

"Don't you love yourself the most?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi paused: "But when I'm still intact, I can still feel sad and hurt because of you."

"Yet you still left so resolutely." Just thinking about that day's scene made Xu Qingzhu want to cry. Tears were welling up in her eyes, and her voice became choked again: "When I woke up that morning, I felt..."

Liang Shi was afraid to hear it, yet also curious.

So she looked at her gently, listening to her speak slowly.

Xu Qingzhu took a deep breath before saying: "That day, I almost jumped off the building."

Actually, from her tone, one could tell that making this request wasn't Liang Shi's intention.

But for Xu Qingzhu, it was an extremely painful thing.

She kept negating herself then rebuilding, negating again, rebuilding again, over and over.

Her mental state reached the breaking point time after time.

Yet even so, she never wailed loudly—she just sat there, numbly shedding tears.

Hearing this, Liang Shi was alarmed: "What were you thinking?"

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes. Half of her tears fell while the other half hung on her eyelashes.

She said quietly: "You probably forgot that I used to have a mental illness."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi's heart felt like it was stuffed with ten thousand sour plums—sour and swollen.

Mist gradually formed in her eyes too.

But Xu Qingzhu looked at her and smiled, lightly licking her lips before slowly leaning down.

Gently closing her eyes, she placed a kiss on Liang Shi's lips.

Lips softly touching lips.

With wet traces of moisture.

Liang Shi felt both angry and upset. "How can you be so foolish?"

"But what can I do?" Xu Qingzhu said. "I had no other choice."

Liang Shi didn't dare look into her eyes anymore. She lowered her gaze and washed Xu Qingzhu's feet.

Xu Qingzhu said again: "Come up here. Let's soak our feet together."

Liang Shi was too embarrassed to go up—she didn't have the face for it.

But then Xu Qingzhu said: "Don't you want to be closer to me?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi also took off her socks and sat beside her.

Their feet touched in the water. Xu Qingzhu's head rested on Liang Shi's shoulder.

The house became quiet—so quiet that they could almost hear each other's heartbeats.

Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu: "When did you find out?"

Xu Qingzhu answered: "About ten days ago."

"Then you..." Liang Shi didn't even dare to ask her directly, speaking somewhat timidly.

But Xu Qingzhu turned her head to face her, both hands cupping her face, their eyes meeting.
"Liang Shi, do you feel very guilty?"

Liang Shi nodded.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Then love me a little more."

Liang Shi's hand rested on the back of her neck as she slowly nodded.

Xu Qingzhu leaned forward, her voice even softer: "Just a little bit is enough."

Liang Shi pressed her lips together. After a long while, as their lips met, she made a sincere and earnest promise: "From now on, I will love you more than I love myself."